

CENTRAL PENNSYLVANIA

Land Development & Investment Real Estate Market Report

York · Lancaster · Dauphin · Cumberland

Susquehanna Valley | August 2026

Current status of land development and investment real estate, plus the operational impact of Pennsylvania Act 52 of 2024 on wholesaling.

Prepared for professional use. Data current through mid-August 2026.

1. Executive Summary

The four-county Susquehanna Valley remains one of the more disciplined, supply-constrained markets in the Northeast. Housing inventory is still critically tight. Industrial and logistics demand along the I-81 corridor continues to absorb land and drive construction. Large-tract residential land deals are slower because financing is still not cheap. Farmland holds its value, with Lancaster remaining the premium agricultural market in the state.

On the investment side, Act 52 of 2024 (effective January 2025) did not ban wholesaling. It professionalized it. Assignment of an equitable interest in residential property is now licensed brokerage activity under RELRA. Unlicensed operators are out. Licensed, disclosure-compliant investors are still in. The 30-day non-waivable seller cancellation right is the operational change that actually matters: you cannot run a 21-day assignment the way you used to.

Bottom line: the market rewards people who already have the license, the corpus of ordinances, the parcel data, and the patience to underwrite entitlement risk. It punishes anyone still trying to flip contracts without taking title and without a license.

2. Residential Market Snapshot

South-central Pennsylvania is still a seller's market. Months of inventory in York and Lancaster sat at 1.39 and 1.32 in May 2026 — down more than 22% year-over-year. Homes go pending in under a week in both counties. That tightness is the single most important fact for anyone looking at finished lots, townhome product, or 55+ inventory.

County	July 2026 Median Sold	YoY	Months Inv.	Med. DOM	Notes
York	\$310,000	+2.0%	1.39	5 days	\$299,900 (May)
Lancaster	\$385,000	+6.9%	1.32	4 days	Record high held June–July
Cumberland	\$341,000	+0.1%	—	—	\$324,856 YTD median
Dauphin	\$291,000	+10.3%	—	—	Largest % gain in Harrisburg metro

Sources: local realtor associations (York/Adams, GHAR, LCAR); ABC27 compilation of July 2026 closings.

York 17402 (Springettsbury) ranked among Realtor.com's hottest ZIP codes nationally in 2026. Lititz (17543) in Lancaster ranked seventh. Demand is spreading into the smaller, commute-manageable markets rather than chasing the lowest price. That is exactly the pattern that supports well-located subdivision ground near I-83 and the Harrisburg employment shed.

3. Land Development Market

3.1 Farmland and Raw Acreage Pricing

Closed-sale ranges from late 2025 through mid-2026, not USDA averages and not listing ask. These are what farms actually traded for.

County / Belt	General Farmland	Premium Tillable	Mountain / Timber
Lancaster (limestone belt)	\$30,000–\$38,000	\$45,000–\$50,000+	\$8,000–\$12,000
York	\$15,000–\$19,000	\$20,000–\$23,000	\$5,000–\$8,000
Cumberland / Dauphin / Lebanon	\$14,000–\$19,000	\$20,000–\$23,000	\$5,000–\$9,000

Source: Aaron Glick, Lime House Realty — actual closed sales, mid-2026.

Lancaster stays at the top because of the Plain-community buyer pool, Lancaster Farmland Trust activity, and neighboring producers competing for quality ground. York and the Cumberland/Dauphin belt sit in a more typical South-Central range.

Development-pressure parcels near I-83, sewer, and employment centers price above these agricultural numbers — sometimes well above — once residual lot-value math is applied.

3.2 Industrial and Entitled Development Land

Central Pennsylvania (Harrisburg–Carlisle–York–Lebanon) remains a core I-81 logistics node. Savills Q2 2026: Central PA held 5.8 million square feet under construction — 43% of the Pennsylvania I-81/78 corridor pipeline. Lower land costs and large-site availability continue to pull speculative and build-to-suit industrial.

Indicative 2026 pricing for the Harrisburg / I-81 corridor: entitled industrial land roughly \$100,000–\$200,000 per acre; raw land near I-81 / I-76 interchanges \$60,000–\$120,000 per acre. Distribution rents in the \$7.50–\$10.50/SF NNN range with vacancy generally 5–8%. York and Lancaster industrial submarkets have shown mixed but generally healthy absorption; construction remains active.

3.3 Residential Subdivision Activity

Finished-lot and townhome demand is supported by the tight resale market. Large raw-land residential transactions have been more limited — financing conditions are described as moderately restrictive but stable (conventional CRE rates locally cited in the mid-6% range). County planning commissions in York and Lancaster continue to review subdivision and land-development plans on a regular cycle. Municipal politics remain the swing factor: some townships stay pro-growth; others have become warehouse-cautious or density-cautious. Entitlement risk has to be underwritten township by township, not county-wide.

Cumberland County Q1 2026 vacant-land closings (15 transactions) showed a median sale of \$145,000 and a wide per-acre range — from roughly \$14,000/acre on a large farm to several hundred thousand per acre on small, utility-served lots. Location and sewer still explain almost all of the variance.

4. Investment Real Estate (Non-Land)

Industrial led commercial performance in recent Central PA reports: strong sales volume, positive absorption in key submarkets, vacancy in the mid-single digits. Multifamily has been resilient — one Q4 regional snapshot showed ~\$214 million in multifamily sales, positive unit absorption, average rents near \$1,446/month, and vacancy around 6%. Office is selective: Class B value-add and smaller efficient suites still lease; trophy vacancy is not the story here the way it is in larger metros.

Investor posture heading through 2026: cautious but present. Cap rates have stabilized after the 2024–2025 rate shock. Local and regional capital is more active than coastal institutional capital on smaller deals. The buyers who win are the ones who already know the municipality, the SALDO, and the utility map.

5. Pennsylvania Wholesaling Law: Act 52 of 2024

Governor Shapiro signed Senate Bill 1173 as Act 52 on July 8, 2024. It took effect in early January 2025 (commonly cited as January 4–9, 2025). As of August 2026 there are no pending amendments. The Pennsylvania Real Estate Commission is actively monitoring complaints.

What the statute actually did

Act 52 amended the Real Estate Licensing and Registration Act (RELRA). It expanded the definitions of “broker” and “salesperson” to include persons who engage in wholesale transactions. A wholesale transaction is defined, in substance, as promoting the sale, exchange, or purchase of an equitable interest in residential real property with the intent to assign or transfer that interest for a fee without having taken title as owner of record.

Practical result: standard assignment wholesaling of residential property in Pennsylvania is licensed real estate activity. The old ownership/exemption theory that unlicensed investors relied on is gone. An unlicensed person cannot recover an assignment fee in Pennsylvania court (RELRA §302). Civil penalties for unlicensed practice can reach \$1,000 per violation, plus summary-offense exposure.

Mandatory contract mechanics

Every wholesale purchase agreement must contain, prominently (not buried in an exhibit):

- A clear statement that the contract is a wholesale transaction and that the buyer intends to assign the interest for a fee without taking title.
- Notice that the seller may consult a licensed appraiser, a non-affiliated licensee, or an attorney before signing.
- A non-waivable right to cancel until midnight of day 30 after execution, or until conveyance, whichever comes first.
- A refund of all payments within 10 business days of a cancellation notice.

Philadelphia adds a separate municipal Residential Property Wholesaler License on top of the statewide Act 52 requirements. Central PA operators are not exempt from the state layer.

5.1 How this changed the investment space

There is no public statewide dataset that cleanly measures “wholesale assignment volume before vs. after January 2025.” The operational effects, however, are not theoretical.

Barrier to entry went up. Pre-licensing education, a salesperson or broker license, and a supervising broker are now the ticket. Fly-by-night contract flippers who marketed other people’s houses without ever intending to close are no longer a viable business model. That was the legislative intent — consumer protection for elderly, distressed, and uninformed sellers — and it is being enforced.

Timelines changed. A non-waivable 30-day seller cancellation right means a standard 21-day assignment is structurally broken. Cash-buyer commitments, earnest money, and marketing have to be built around a minimum 30-day window. Marketing a deal hard during that window creates the risk that the seller walks after you have already spent money and shown the property to end buyers.

Compliant volume still exists. Pennsylvania remains a high-REO, judicial-foreclosure state. ATTOM data cited in 2026 investor guides placed the Commonwealth among the top five states for completed REOs in early 2026. Harrisburg and the surrounding counties are treated as a viable secondary-market wholesale environment for licensed operators, with typical assignment-fee ranges in investor literature of roughly \$6,000–\$15,000 on Harrisburg-area product. Those numbers assume Act 52-compliant contracts and a licensed principal.

Double-close vs. assignment. The statute is written around assignment of an equitable interest without taking title. Taking title and then conveying (a true double close) sits in a different legal posture. It is slower, more expensive, and still requires honest marketing. It is not a magic workaround, and it should not be treated as one without counsel.

Net effect on Central PA: fewer unlicensed assignment shops, more deals flowing through licensed brokerages and investor-operators who already sit at the table, and a cleaner paper trail. Distressed inventory did not disappear. The people who could legally touch it changed.

6. Outlook and Positioning

Through the rest of 2026 and into 2027, expect more of the same: tight resale housing, continued industrial absorption along I-81, township-level entitlement fights, and a licensed-only wholesale channel. Land that already has sewer, frontage, and a realistic SALDO path will keep trading at a premium to farmland comps. Unentitled acreage will sit until residual math and rates line up.

The operators who win in this four-county market are the ones who treat zoning, ordinances, and parcel data as infrastructure — not as a last-minute Google search. A unified map, parcel search, and document corpus covering every municipality in York, Dauphin, Cumberland, and Lancaster is not a nice-to-have. It is the difference between underwriting a deal in an afternoon and bleeding weeks on county-by-county scavenger hunts.

7. Primary Sources

- Aaron Glick / Lime House Realty — Pennsylvania Farmland Values Per Acre 2026 (closed-sale ranges, mid-2026).
- Savills USA — Pennsylvania I-81/78 Corridor Q2 2026 Industrial Market Report.
- JLL — Eastern and Central Pennsylvania Industrial Market Dynamics, Q2 2026.
- Bill Gladstone Group — Central PA Commercial Real Estate Outlook 2026.
- Realtors Association of York & Adams Counties; Greater Harrisburg Association of Realtors; Lancaster County Association of Realtors — 2026 monthly statistics.
- ABC27 / local association compilation — July 2026 Southcentral PA housing medians.
- Realtor.com hottest-ZIP rankings, August 2026 (York 17402; Lancaster 17543).
- Cumberland County vacant-land Q1 2026 closing summary (Josh Schoenly / EXP).
- Pennsylvania Act 52 of 2024 (SB 1173); RELRA amendments; Pennsylvania Association of Realtors wholesaling overview.
- Pennsylvania Real Estate Commission enforcement posture as reported in 2026 practitioner guides (no pending amendments as of mid-2026).
- York County Planning Commission — Subdivision Activity Reports and review-fee schedule.
- Lancaster County Planning Department — S/LD review process.
- LandAdvisor / regional industrial land pricing notes for Central PA I-81 corridor.

This report is market intelligence for professional use. It is not legal advice, not an appraisal, and not an offer to buy or sell. Act 52 compliance requires a Pennsylvania real estate license and current counsel. Township ordinances, SALDO, and utility availability change; verify against the municipal corpus before you underwrite.